

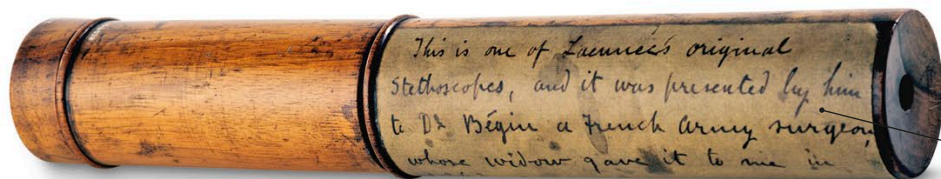
Better diagnoses

Until around 200 years ago, the only tools doctors had for identifying illnesses were their own expertise and the patients' descriptions of their symptoms. Since then, a wide array of instruments for testing patients' health and working out what their symptoms mean has been developed. This has helped to turn diagnosis from a guessing game into something more scientific.

FAST FACTS

- The ancient Greeks first came up with the term "diagnosis," meaning to identify an illness. They believed illnesses were caused by an excess or lack of four body fluids called humors: blood, yellow bile, black bile, and phlegm.
- In the 19th century, some scientists believed that someone's mental health could be diagnosed by phrenology—the study of the shape and size of a person's head.

Laënnec's stethoscope



Single hollow tube made of wood and brass

Listening in

- **What?** Stethoscope
- **Who?** René Laënnec
- **Where and when?** France, 1816

A stethoscope is used to listen to sounds made by the lungs and heart to detect any abnormal activity. The first stethoscope

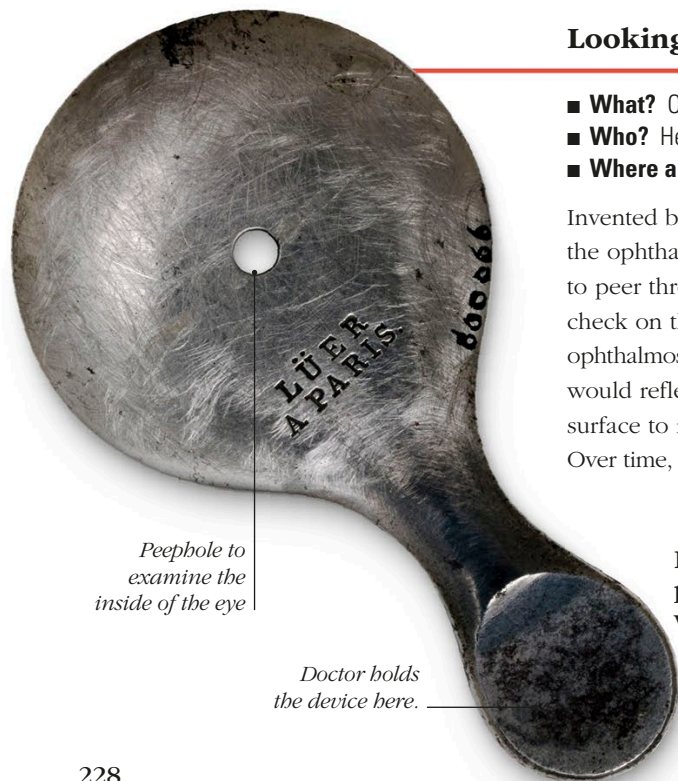
was a simple wooden tube that could be held against the chest of a patient. Modern versions with chest pieces, rubber tubing, and ear plugs (so a doctor can listen with both ears) were not developed until later in the 19th century.

Looking in

- **What?** Ophthalmoscope
- **Who?** Hermann von Helmholtz
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1851

Invented by a German physician, the ophthalmoscope allows a doctor to peer through a patient's pupil to check on the health of the eye. In early ophthalmoscopes, light from a candle would reflect off the device's mirrored surface to illuminate the patient's eye. Over time, electric lights replaced candles.

French ophthalmoscope, produced after Helmholtz's version, mid-19th century



Peephole to examine the inside of the eye

Doctor holds the device here.

